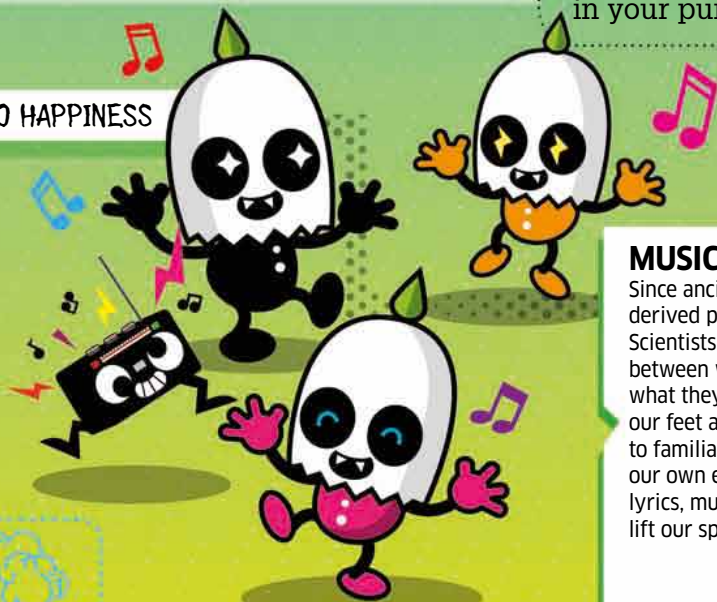


WHAT IS THE SECRET TO HAPPINESS?

If there were a single formula for happiness, it would be the world's best-selling product. However, studies carried out by scientists and psychologists show that a variety of things make people happy, and what puts a smile on one person's face will not please everyone. Though individuals have their own ideas about what constitutes contentment, certain factors that influence happiness are shared by many. Take a look to see which ones play a part in your pursuit of happiness . . .

ROAD TO HAPPINESS



MUSIC

Since ancient times, people have derived pleasure from music. Scientists have studied the link between what people hear and what they feel. Whether tapping our feet and clicking our fingers to familiar rhythms or relating our own experiences to emotive lyrics, music has the power to lift our spirits.

NATURAL HIGHS

The human brain and nervous system produce and release chemical neurotransmitters called endorphins. These are usually secreted to relieve stress or pain, and they create euphoric feelings in the process. Yet something as simple as eating chocolate can also release endorphins and result in a happy state of mind. There are at least 20 different types of endorphins, and levels vary from person to person.



VACATIONS

It will come as no surprise to learn that vacations go hand in hand with happiness. The happiest time is said to be anticipating the vacation in the days before departure. Scientists claim that the benefits of a break can make people feel happier for up to two months after their return.

ESCAPISM

Experiencing the arts gives people a chance to turn off from their everyday lives and escape into imaginary worlds, whether sitting down with a good book, catching the latest movie at the theater, or seeing a play. As well as bringing happiness, these forms of escapism fire the imagination and encourage creativity.

EXERCISE

It may be nightmare news for couch potatoes everywhere, but exercise has been proven to be just as effective as prescription drugs in treating depression. As well as the obvious health benefits, regular exercise releases "happy chemicals" in the brain and creates a sense of achievement.

